

Determining the Crystalline Structure of Metals through X-Ray Diffraction

Shukri Alex, Weltz Michael

McGill University Department of Physics

Supervisor: Prof. David Cooke

October 5, 2026

Abstract

This experiment set out to measure X-ray diffraction patterns of various solid samples in order to describe their crystal structure at the atomic/molecular level. An already calibrated Siemen !!!!!MODEL NAME!!!! X-Ray diffractometer was used to send X-rays into Copper (Cu), Nickel (Ni), CuNi alloy, Titanium (Sn), Lead (Pb), PbSn alloy and two mystery samples named A and B.

Any crystalline solid consists of a regular 3-dimensional packing of cells, the shape of which corresponds to one of fourteen Bravais lattices. These 3D patterns create multiple parallel planar layers within the crystal of various orientations. X-Rays travelling through these planes will diffract off the atoms and constructively interfere at the detector, creating a peak in photon count in the observed diffraction pattern. From that peak, Bragg's law $n\lambda = 2d \sin \theta$ (where $n = 1$ for a first-order plane) can be used to deduce the inter-planar distance d of the diffraction plane of the crystal. Using this inter-planar distance and the corresponding Miller indices, the Bravais lattice can be determined and the lattice parameter(s) calculated. The Cu and Ni pure samples and alloys were found to have a Face-Centered Cubic (FCC) Bravais lattice, with single lattice parameters [...] respectively. The alloy samples of these two was found to have [...]. The Sn and Pb samples were found to have a lattice of [...] and parameters [...] respectively, and their alloy [...], [...]. Finally, the mystery samples A and B were determined to be [...] and [...], with lattices [...] and parameters [...], respectively.

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1 Introduction

A solid can serve as a diffraction grating for X-rays of wavelengths similar to the lengths of inter-atomic distances. Similarly to how light diffracts, X-rays can also diffract off of atoms. Atoms within solids will arrange themselves in symmetries, formally called cells, given by one of one of fourteen Bravais lattices, with each lattice grouped into one of seven crystal systems. These Bravais lattices govern along which diffraction planes atoms may align and Miller indices are conventionally used to index the various planes. Appendix 6.1 shows the different Bravais lattices. If an X-ray is sent to a solid with an angle θ such that constructive interference occurs at a detector placed 2θ with respect to the incident ray, a peak in intensity of photons may be observed. From this, one can obtain a relation between the inter-planar distance d , the incident angle θ , and the wavelength λ .

$$n\lambda = 2d \sin(\theta) \quad (1)$$

with $n = 1$ for our purposes. Equation 1 is formally called Bragg's Law.

Using these observed peaks and (1), the distance d between the parallel diffraction planes can be obtained and related to the Bravais lattice and Miller indices by various equations. For a cubic system, this relation takes the form of

$$\frac{1}{d^2} = \frac{h^2 + k^2 + l^2}{a^2} \quad (2)$$

where h, k, l are the Miller Indices and a is the length of the cube edge. Similar equations for different crystal systems are given in 6.1.

2 Methods

2.1 Instrument and Data Acquisition

The apparatus consisted of a pre-calibrated Siemens SD5000 diffractometer. The X-ray tube used Copper K_α radiation. Two sets of filters of 0.6 mm were present on the X-ray tube

and the detector. During data acquisition, the diffractometer was set to 40 kV and 40 mA. A computer connected to the apparatus was used to specify the measurement parameters and obtain the data from the instrument.

Data acquisition consisted in mounting the sample on the mounting plate, opening the parameter file in the computer software and executing the job. Once the job is executed, the detector rotates about the mounting plate to be at an angle of $2\theta_0 = 5.00^\circ$ with respect to the incident rays and the mounting plate rotates about itself to make an angle of θ_0 . The detector and mounting plate rotate with angle increments of $2\Delta\theta = 0.05$ and $\Delta\theta$, respectively, with 2.00 s at each step until reaching $2\theta = 110.00^\circ$.

Measurements were taken for samples of Copper, Nickel, Tin, Lead; 25%, 50% and 75% alloys of Copper-Nickel and Tin-lead, and two mystery samples A and B. Three trials were initially done for Copper and Nickel, and two trials were done for the other samples. It was found that the uncertainties associated to statistical fluctuations of two measurements were smaller than that of the standard deviation of gaussians fitted about the intensity peaks.

2.2 Data Analysis

For a given sample, the acquired data is used to plot intensity against 2θ . From the plots, local maxima of intensity are obtained and gaussians are fitted against individual peaks, yielding an uncertainty for each. Noise is accounted for by taking an average of the intensities where there are no peaks, and subtracting it from the peaks. The Gaussians are then summed and plotted. From the means of the gaussians the angle of diffraction is obtained and used to find the inter-planar distance (for that given peak), using equation 1. Consider the set of equation in Appendix 6.1 relating d and the Miller indices. For every d spacing, we want to find what the sum of the Miller indices are. These will always be integers, so the goal is to make a guess on h, k, l , find the lattice constant(s), and check for consistency. For example, in a cubic system, we can simply plot the selection rules for a given Bravais lattice against the expected d values, and compare with the experimental d values. The experimental d values should align along one of the Bravais lattices (either FCC, BCC, SC). For tetragonal and Hexagonal systems, it becomes more of a guessing game. Notice that

3 Results

The fitted gaussian sums with residuals for the Cu and Ni samples and alloys are shown.

In figure 3, the residuals for the Ni samples are shown, and from their numerical results in table ?? we can observe that random error from trial to trial is minimal compared with noise error provided by the Gaussian fits. The fitted gaussian sums with residuals for the Cu and Ni samples and alloys are shown in the same appendix, in figure 4. From these, the inter-planar distances were calculated and are shown in table 1. These were plotted against expected results for all 3 types of cubic Bravais lattices, and the best fit was found to be the Face-Centered Cubic (FCC) lattice, as shown below in figure 1. The lattice parameters were then calculated and are shown in table 1.

Sample	a_{exp} (Å)	a_{theory} (Å)	Δa (Å)
Ni	3.5223 ± 0.0001	3.5238	-0.0015 ± 0.0001
Cu	3.6126 ± 0.0001	3.6149	-0.0023 ± 0.0001
Cu ₂₅ Ni ₇₅	3.5415 ± 0.0002	3.5467	-0.0052 ± 0.0002
Cu ₅₀ Ni ₅₀	3.5629 ± 0.0003	3.5696	-0.0067 ± 0.0003
Cu ₇₅ Ni ₂₅	3.5864 ± 0.0002	3.5924	-0.0060 ± 0.0002

Table 1: Experimental and theoretical lattice parameters for Cu, Ni pure samples and alloys. The theoretical values for the alloys are calculated using Vegard’s law .

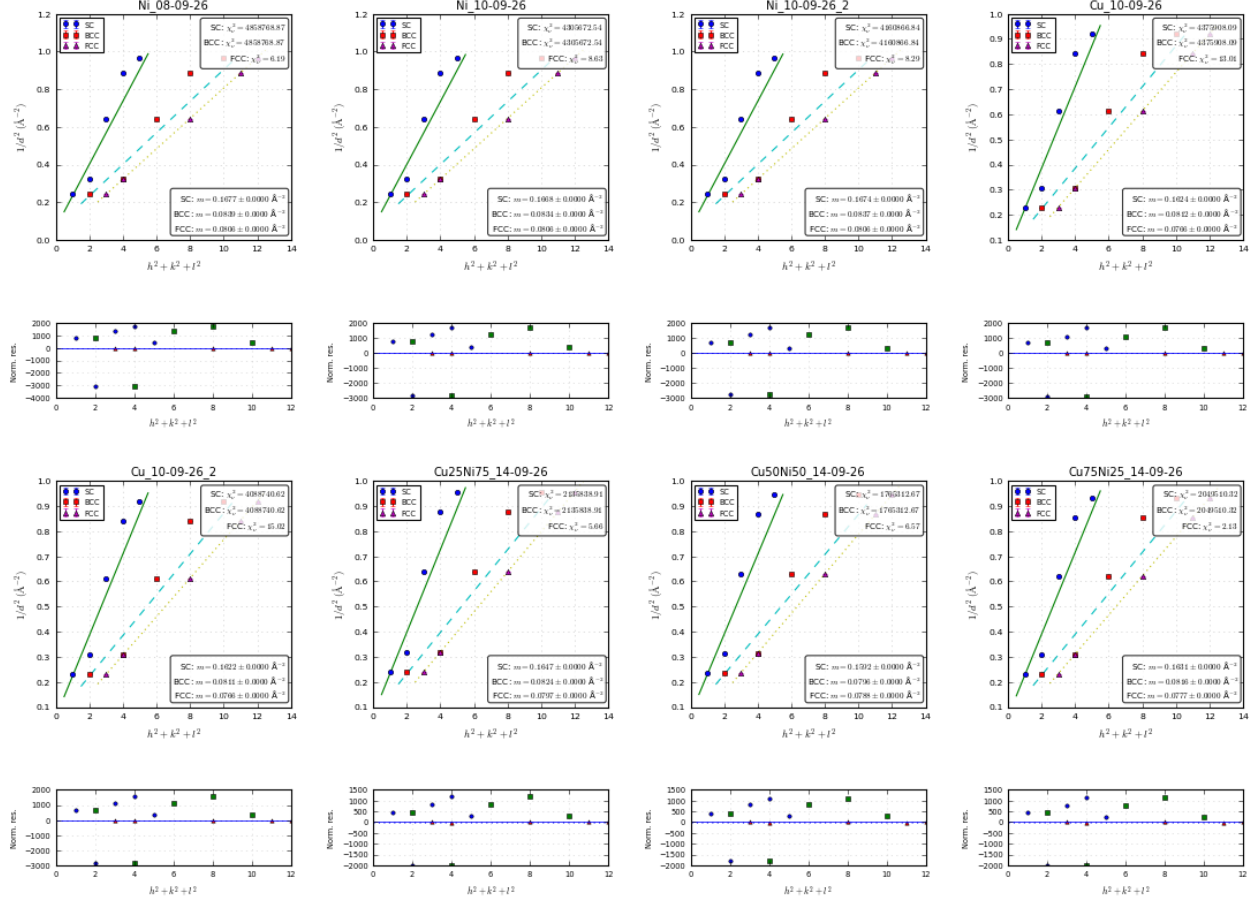


Figure 1: Determination of Cubic crystal structure and lattice parameter for Cu and Ni.

4 Discussion

The results for the Cu and Ni pure samples and alloys are consistent with the literature values, with the experimental values being within 0.2% of the theoretical values. The small discrepancies can be attributed to background noise in the acquired data. The determination of the Face-Centered Cubic (FCC) Bravais lattice for these samples is also consistent with known crystal structures for Cu and Ni. While running multiple trials does not reduce error much, it could still be worth it, as random error is of similar order as the noise error. The results for the Pb, Sn, and PbSn alloys are still to be determined, as well as the mystery samples A and B.

5 Conclusion

6 Appendix

6.1 Inter-planar distance, Bravais Lattices and Miller indices

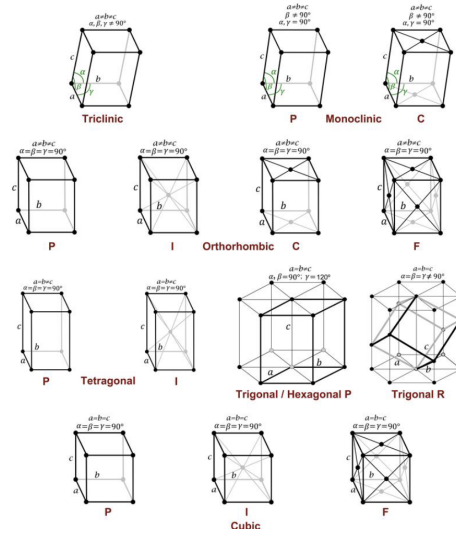


Figure 2: Fourteen Bravais lattices and their associated seven groups.

For the following equations: d is the inter planar distance, a, b, c the inter-atomic distances, h, k, l the indices for a given Miller index (hkl) .

Cubic:

$$\frac{1}{d^2} = \frac{h^2 + k^2 + l^2}{a^2}$$

Tetragonal:

$$\frac{1}{d^2} = \frac{h^2 + k^2}{a^2} + \frac{l^2}{c^2}$$

Hexagonal:

$$\frac{1}{d^2} = \frac{4}{3} \left(\frac{h^2 + k^2 + hk}{a^2} \right) + \frac{l^2}{c^2}$$

Orthorhombic:

$$\frac{1}{d^2} = \frac{h^2}{a^2} + \frac{k^2}{b^2} + \frac{l^2}{c^2}$$

Vegard's law:

$$a_{\text{alloy}} = xa_{\text{Cu}} + (1 - x)a_{\text{Ni}}$$

6.2 Supplementary Figures and Tables

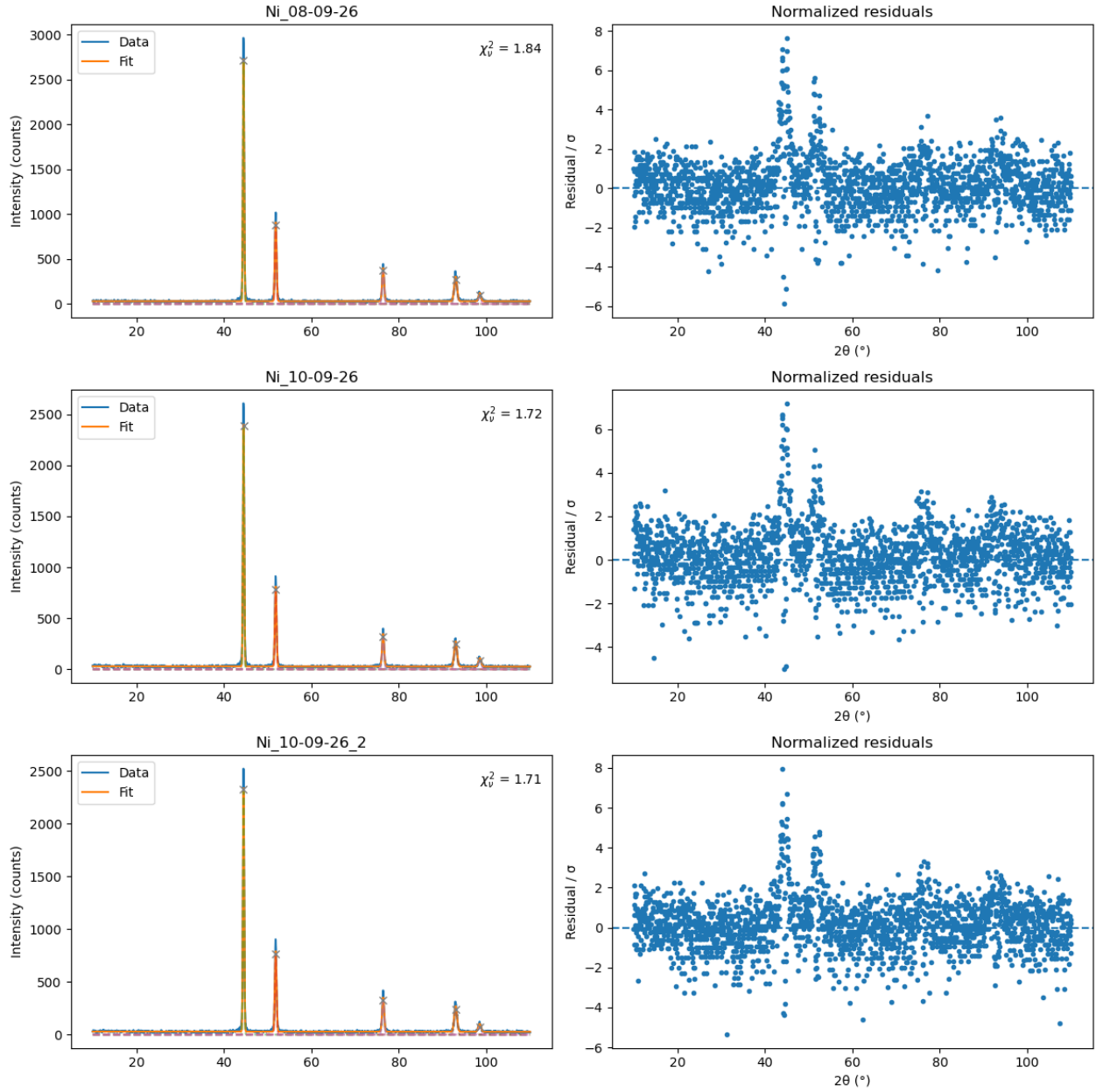


Figure 3: Gaussian sum fits of all pure Ni trials with residuals

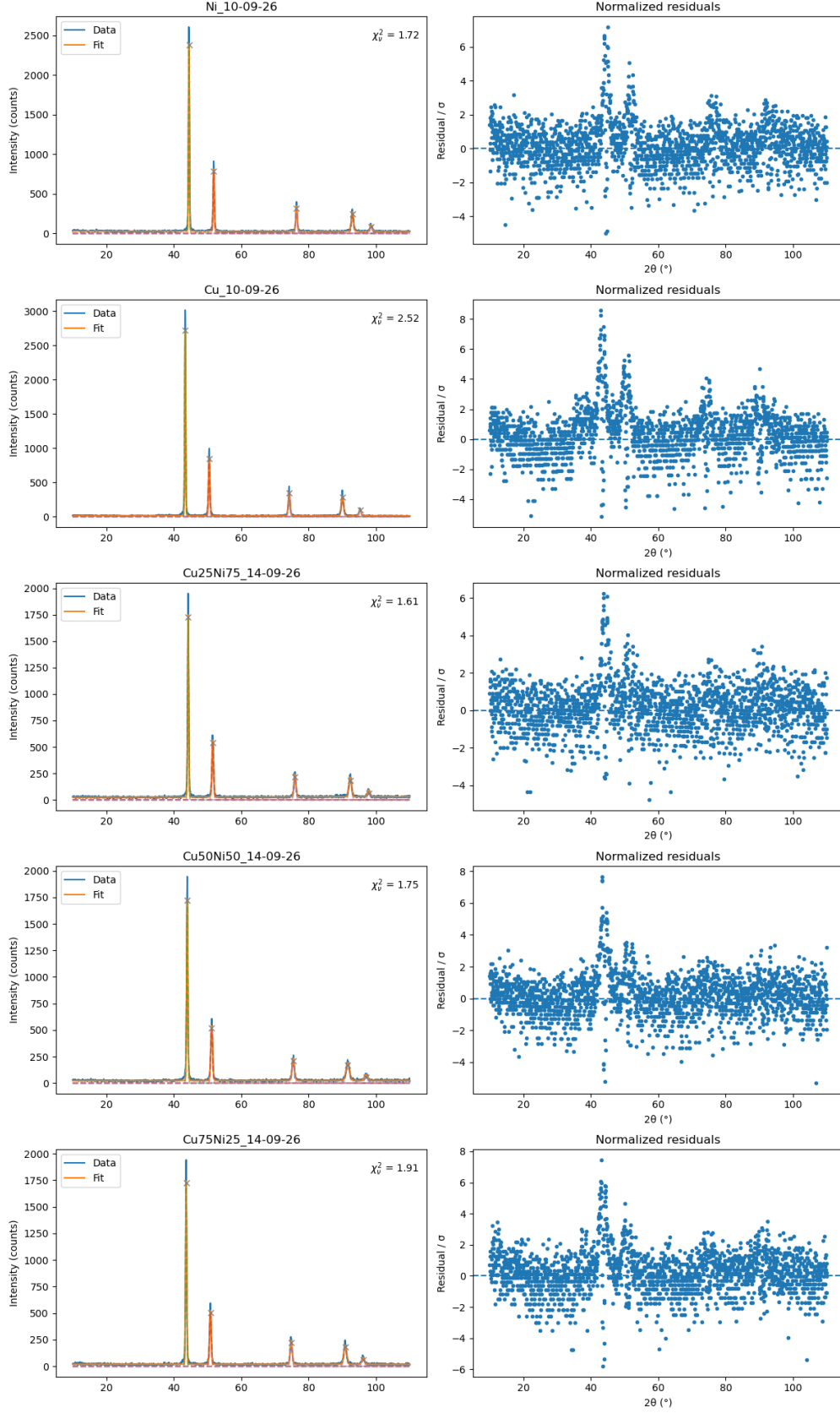


Figure 4: Gaussian sum fits with residuals of the Cu and Ni pure and alloy samples

Ni trial 1			Ni trial 2		
Peak	2θ (°)	d (Å)	Peak	2θ (°)	d (Å)
1	44.4819 ± 0.0011	2.03512 ± 0.00005	1	44.4843 ± 0.0011	2.03502 ± 0.00005
2	51.8330 ± 0.0023	1.76246 ± 0.00007	2	51.8331 ± 0.0024	1.76245 ± 0.00008
3	76.3993 ± 0.0041	1.24563 ± 0.00006	3	76.3933 ± 0.0045	1.24571 ± 0.00006
4	92.9684 ± 0.0059	1.06221 ± 0.00005	4	92.9701 ± 0.0062	1.06220 ± 0.00005
5	98.4832 ± 0.0109	1.01694 ± 0.00008	5	98.5025 ± 0.0127	1.01679 ± 0.00010
Ni trial 3			Cu trial 1		
Peak	2θ (°)	d (Å)	Peak	2θ (°)	d (Å)
1	44.4810 ± 0.0012	2.03517 ± 0.00005	1	43.3661 ± 0.0011	2.08487 ± 0.00005
2	51.8307 ± 0.0024	1.76253 ± 0.00008	2	50.4888 ± 0.0024	1.80618 ± 0.00008
3	76.4023 ± 0.0045	1.24558 ± 0.00006	3	74.2095 ± 0.0043	1.27687 ± 0.00006
4	92.9767 ± 0.0062	1.06214 ± 0.00005	4	90.0228 ± 0.0054	1.08915 ± 0.00005
5	98.4665 ± 0.0135	1.01707 ± 0.00010	5	95.2553 ± 0.0097	1.04266 ± 0.00008
Cu trial 2			Cu ₂₅ Ni ₇₅		
Peak	2θ (°)	d (Å)	Peak	2θ (°)	d (Å)
1	43.3667 ± 0.0011	2.08484 ± 0.00005	1	44.2433 ± 0.0015	2.04554 ± 0.00006
2	50.4882 ± 0.0024	1.80620 ± 0.00008	2	51.5406 ± 0.0034	1.77176 ± 0.00011
3	74.2000 ± 0.0043	1.27701 ± 0.00006	3	75.9226 ± 0.0065	1.25226 ± 0.00009
4	90.0104 ± 0.0057	1.08927 ± 0.00005	4	92.3239 ± 0.0085	1.06793 ± 0.00008
5	95.2715 ± 0.0098	1.04253 ± 0.00008	5	97.7855 ± 0.0166	1.02232 ± 0.00013
Cu ₅₀ Ni ₅₀			Cu ₇₅ Ni ₂₅		
Peak	2θ (°)	d (Å)	Peak	2θ (°)	d (Å)
1	43.9763 ± 0.0016	2.05734 ± 0.00007	1	43.6499 ± 0.0015	2.07197 ± 0.00007
2	51.2219 ± 0.0036	1.78204 ± 0.00012	2	50.8455 ± 0.0035	1.79434 ± 0.00011
3	75.4112 ± 0.0071	1.25948 ± 0.00010	3	74.8037 ± 0.0062	1.26819 ± 0.00009
4	91.6044 ± 0.0098	1.07443 ± 0.00009	4	90.8289 ± 0.0083	1.08157 ± 0.00008
5	97.0016 ± 0.0200	1.02849 ± 0.00016	5	96.1327 ± 0.0160	1.03546 ± 0.00013

Table 2: Measured X-ray diffraction peak angular positions and corresponding interplanar spacings (d) for the Ni, Cu, and Cu–Ni alloy samples.